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A Political Storm

If the coup in the boardroom was not enough, SSNCo was soon headed into a political storm that rattled the company, setting it inexorably on the path of destruction.

The few months preceding and following the historic Surat session of the Indian National Congress in December 1908 proved to be the high watermark for the Swadeshi movement in south India. It also turned out to be testing times for SSNCo. The growing strength of the movement in Tirunelveli district, especially in Tuticorin, seriously challenged the authority of the state and drew its ire.

As is clear from the narrative thus far, the Government of Madras kept a close watch on the birth and growth of SSNCo and was alert to its political intent and objectives. The local administration—from the port officers to the local police to the sub-collector to the district collector—not only had their nose to the ground, they also intervened in a biased manner. It was no secret that they were hand-in-glove with BI.